Preventing Medical Mistakes

Medical mistakes continue to be a significant cause of preventable deaths within the United States. While death is the most tragic outcome, medical mistakes cause other problems such as permanent disabilities, extended hospital stays, longer recoveries, and even additional treatments. Medical mistakes and their consequences also add significantly to the overall cost of healthcare. Hospitals and healthcare providers are being held accountable for the quality of care and reduction in medical mistakes by their accrediting bodies. You can also improve the quality and safety of your own healthcare and that of your family members by learning more about and understanding your risks. Take these simple steps:

1. Ask questions if you have doubts or concerns.

- Ask questions and make sure you understand the answers.
- Choose a doctor with whom you feel comfortable talking.
- Take a relative or friend with you to help you take notes, ask questions, and understand answers.

2. Keep and bring a list of all the medications you take.

- Bring the actual medication or give your doctor and pharmacist a list of all the medications and dosages that you take, including non-prescription (over the counter) medications and nutritional supplements.
- Tell your doctor and pharmacist about any drug, food, and other allergies you have, such as latex.
- Ask about any risks or side effects of the medication and what to avoid while taking it. Be sure to write down what your doctor or pharmacist says.
- Make sure your medication is what the doctor ordered. Ask the pharmacist about your medication if it looks different than you expected.
- Read the label and patient package insert when you get your medication, including all warnings and instructions.
- Know how to use your medication. Especially note the times and conditions when your medication should and should not be taken.
- Contact your doctor or pharmacist if you have any questions.
- Understanding both the generic and brand names for all of your medication(s) is important. This helps ensure you do not receive double dosing from taking both a generic and a brand of the same medication. It also helps you avoid taking a medication to which you are allergic.

3. Get the results of any test or procedure.

- Ask when and how you will get the results of tests or procedures. Will it be in person, by phone, mail, through the Plan or Provider's portal?
- Don't assume the results are fine if you do not get them when expected. Contact your healthcare provider and ask for your results.
- Ask what the results mean for your care.

4. Talk to your doctor about which hospital or clinic is best for your health needs.

- Ask your doctor about which hospital or clinic has the best care and results for your condition if you have more than one hospital or clinic to choose from to get the healthcare you need.
- Be sure you understand the instructions you get about follow-up care when you leave the hospital or clinic.

5. Make sure you understand what will happen if you need surgery.

- Make sure you, your doctor, and your surgeon all agree on exactly what will be done during the operation.
- Ask your doctor, "Who will manage my care when I am in the hospital?"